

Cohort.

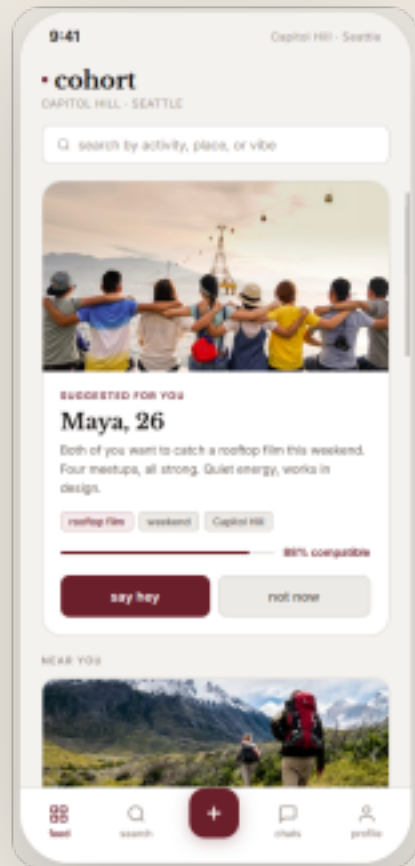
your person for today.

12 interviews · 4 personas · 4 prototype versions ·

\$49B market

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SECTION 01

The Problem

It started with a swim class.

“I wanted to learn swimming but felt self-conscious being 27 in a beginner class. I also wanted a reading buddy, a gossip buddy, a 4th for pickleball. **Not a friend forever. Just the right person for today.**”

The embarrassment gap

Beginner rooms feel exposing when you're older than everyone in them.

The ask is specific

Not friendship — a swim buddy, a reading partner, a fourth for pickleball.

The apps she tried got it wrong

Each one built for lasting friendship when all she needed was today.

Existing apps solve the wrong problem.

57%

of Americans report loneliness

Cigna, 2025

\$0

revenue generated by the BFF app

Bumble Inc., 2025 Form 10-K

12 interviews. 5 questions.

THE 5 QUESTIONS

- 1 When did you last skip something because you had no one to go with?
- 2 What did you do instead?
- 3 Which apps have you tried to meet people — and why did you stop?
- 4 Describe the last time you wanted company for one specific thing.
- 5 What would make you message a stranger to do it together?

WHO WE TALKED TO

Sarah, 24 new-city transplant

Priya, 27 ambitious professional

Aisha, 22 college student

Lily, 31 solo traveler

Emma, 38 new mom

Mei, 28 expat

Ethan, 29 introverted engineer

Miguel, 34 recently divorced

David, 45 busy parent

Jason, 26 gym enthusiast

Noah, 30 creative freelancer

Raj, 32 hyper-independent

3 patterns across all 12 interviews.

01

The “I didn't go” problem

Most interviewees had skipped something they wanted to do, simply because they had no one to go with.

“I really wanted to go, but going alone felt sad — so I just didn't.”

02

Apps failed everyone

Interviewees described Bumble BFF, Meetup and Discord as too heavy, too transactional, or too much commitment.

“It's either 40 strangers or a pen-pal. Nothing in between.”

03

The ask is specific & time-bound

Most weren't looking for a new best friend. They wanted a hiking partner this Sunday.

“I don't need a friend. I need someone to do this one thing.”

SECTION 02

User Personas

Four people, one unmet need.

Sarah, 24

The New City Explorer

"I just moved here — I want to actually do things."

rooftop movies

weekend adventures

new-city social

Ethan, 29

The Introverted Pragmatist

"I'm fine alone — I just want it to be safe."

weekend hikes

matched pace

low pressure

Priya, 27

The Ambitious Professional

"I need peers, not more contacts."

accountability

networking

mutual growth

Raj, 32

The Hyper-Independent Specialist

"I need the right person, not just someone."

chess at my rating

precise matching

no community

Deep dive: Sarah & Ethan

Sarah, 24 · The New City Explorer

"I saved twelve rooftop movie nights this summer. I went to none of them."

PAIN POINTS

- Skips events because going alone feels worse than missing out
- Bumble BFF conversations die before they become plans
- Saves events she never ends up attending

Win moment — finds a movie partner in minutes, and actually goes.

Needs: a fast, low-pressure way to find someone for the same activity, at the same time.

Ethan, 29 · The Introverted Pragmatist

"I'm happy hiking alone — I just don't want to be alone if something goes wrong."

PAIN POINTS

- Avoids remote hikes he'd love because solo feels unsafe
- Can't find partners who match his pace
- Meetup groups are too big and too social

Win moment — finds a reliable hiking partner at his level.

Needs: a dependable way to find compatible partners without the social pressure.

Deep dive: Priya & Raj

Priya, 27 · The Ambitious Professional

"I have 800 LinkedIn connections and no one to actually grow with."

PAIN POINTS

- Skips networking events that feel performative
- LinkedIn stays surface-level
- Consumes career content alone, with no one to push her

Win moment — finds an accountability partner with the same drive.

Needs: ambitious peers genuinely committed to mutual growth.

Raj, 32 · The Hyper-Independent Specialist

"I don't need a community. I need one person at exactly my level."

PAIN POINTS

- Platforms optimize for friendship, not precision
- Can't find someone at his exact skill level
- Groups have mismatched commitment

Win moment — finds a chess partner at his exact rating.

Needs: precise matching — without community filtering in the way.

SECTION 03

Competitive Analysis

Five apps, one recurring gap.

FRIENDSHIP

Bumble BFF

Optimises for long-term friendship when Sarah just needs a Saturday partner.

GROUP EVENTS

Meetup

Solves for groups when Ethan wants one person.

SERENDIPITY

Timeleft

Optimizes for facilitated dinners, not Priya's intentional career goals.

FRIENDSHIP

Frindow

No precision matching for Raj's skill level.

LIFE STAGE

Peanut

Too vertical to serve general use.

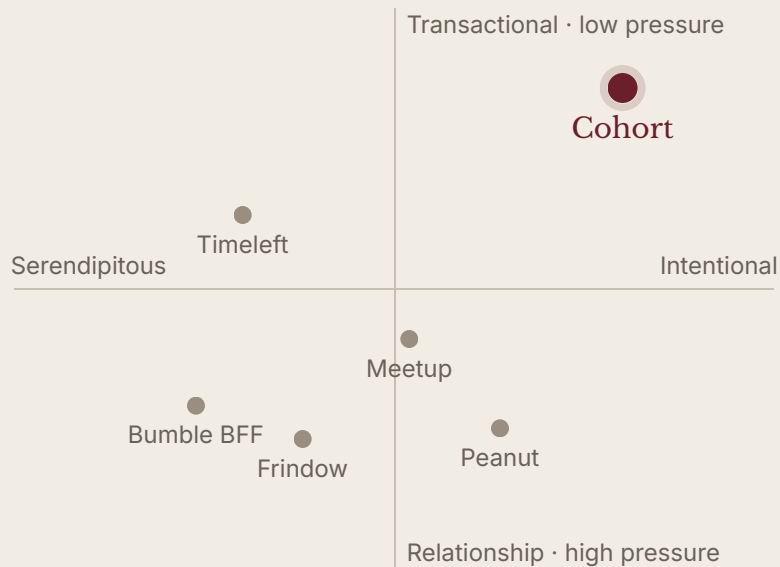
None of the five products we reviewed makes real-time activity intent the primary unit of matching. Each ultimately centers the person or group you meet, rather than the specific activity.

Where Cohort stands alone.

	Purpose-first	1-on-1 match	Skill matching	Real-time intent	No friend pressure
Cohort	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Bumble BFF	✗	✓	✗	✗	✗
Meetup	—	✗	✗	✗	✓
Timeleft	✗	✗	✗	—	✓
Frindow	✗	✓	✗	✗	✗
Peanut	—	✓	✗	✗	✗

03 · COMPETITIVE ANALYSIS

An empty quadrant, waiting.



*Cohort occupies the top-right quadrant — **high intent, low relationship pressure** — which none of the products we reviewed currently owns.*

Four gaps our reviewed products leave open.

Purpose-first matching

None of the five products we reviewed makes user-defined activity intent the primary matching input. Cohort asks *what* you want to do.

Real-time intent

None makes “I want to do X this weekend” the primary matching intent.

Skill-level matching

Raj can’t find this level of activity-specific precision in the products we reviewed.

Zero friendship pressure

One-time, no-commitment pairings as the default.

SECTION 04

Market Sizing

From category to beachhead.

\$49B TAM

Global social networking app market — total category spend, all social apps · Global Insight Services, 2024

\$1.1B SAM

Modeled U.S. target market — $\approx 30\text{M}$ urban US adults 22–45 $\times \approx \$36/\text{user}$ · US Census Bureau

\$14.4M SOM

5 launch cities $\times \approx 80\text{K}$ active users $\times \approx \$36/\text{user}$ = **\$14.4M modeled annual revenue opportunity**, alongside a **\$2M Year 2 operating target** — two separate figures, not a forecast of one another. · Illustrative model based on Cohort assumptions.

\$36/user is a blended planning assumption across venue, experience, B2B and data revenue streams.

SECTION 05

The Product

Three layers, one job.

Discovery Layer

Feed · search · AI auto-categorization of every post.

Matching Layer

THE CORE

Gender / age constraints · interests · pace · skill · proximity · AI best-match suggestion.

Trust Layer

Verified accounts · meetup history · reporting · AI behavior flags.

Three core product decisions.

DECISION 01

Post structure

A post is a **plan**, not a profile: activity + date/time + optional location + one line of context.

- Hashtags optional — AI categorizes every post in the background
- Smart tagging: “coffee and conversation” also surfaces for “going out”
- Writing a post takes under 30 seconds

Why it matters

Intent is captured at the moment it exists, so matching starts from what you want to do — not from who you are.

DECISION 02

Matching flow

Post goes public → someone sends a request → AI surfaces the best match → both see profiles before connecting.

- Ranked on shared interests, pace, proximity and past activity
- No swiping and no queue — the post does the work
- Nobody is contacted without a post to respond to

Why it matters

The shortest possible path from “I want to do this” to “we’re doing it” — Sarah’s two-hour match, not a two-week chat.

DECISION 03

Profile visibility

Public profiles may improve acceptance, shown to you as a nudge. Private still works — but may reduce acceptance.

- The trade-off is stated plainly, never hidden in settings
- Private mode keeps cautious users in the product
- No dark patterns pushing you to expose more

Why it matters

Transparency *is* the trust mechanism. Cohort doesn’t need users to return for the same person — it needs them to return for the next thing they want to do.

Safety, built in at the gate.

Verified profiles	Phone + social link — a hard gate at signup.
Gender filter	Set per post.
Age range filter	Set per post.
AI behavior flags	Unusual patterns trigger review.
First-meetup nudge	Suggests public venues for the first meet.

48% of online dating users report at least one unwanted behavior. — Pew Research, 2023

Cohort's verification gate is designed to make anonymous abuse harder at signup.

SECTION 06

Prototype

Three versions before it worked.

Each version was tested with people from the interview group. Every one of them broke somewhere useful — and each break changed a product decision.

VERSION 1

The profile-first app

What we built: profiles and interests up front, browse people, then message them about doing something.

What went wrong

It became Bumble BFF again. Testers browsed, chatted politely and never made a plan — nobody wanted to be the one to suggest an activity.

What changed

The activity, not the person, became the thing you post.

VERSION 2

The open activity feed

What we built: one public feed of posted activities, an empty box to write your own, open to anyone to reply.

What went wrong

Two problems. The blank box froze people — they didn't know what to write. And replies from complete strangers with no verification felt unsafe, especially to women testers.

What changed

Guided prompts replaced the blank box; verification became a gate, not an option.

VERSION 3

The over-filtered app

What we built: verification, plus filters for gender, age, skill level, pace and distance on every post.

What went wrong

Safety felt solid, but posting took too long and the filters emptied the feed — Raj loved the precision, Sarah gave up before finishing a post.

What changed

Safety filters stayed; preference filters became optional and moved to the AI.

The final version.

Post a plan in under 30 seconds. Verified people only.
The app does the sorting.

Everything the three earlier versions got wrong pointed the same way: make posting effortless, make safety non-negotiable, and move the hard thinking from the user to the system.

Guided posting

Prompts and suggested activities instead of a blank box. Fixes the V2 freeze.

Verification as a gate

Phone + one social link before you can post or reply. Fixes the V2 safety gap.

AI does the filtering

Trust controls — verification, reporting, AI behavior flags — are always on. In the matching layer, gender and age stay manual constraints; interests, pace and skill are inferred. Fixes the V3 friction.

Activity-first feed

You join a plan, not a person. Fixes the V1 chat-that-goes-nowhere problem.

Profiles before connecting

Both sides see each other before a single message. Private mode still works.

Rate after, both ways

Closes the loop, feeds the AI, and powers the north star metric.

Intent to plan — and the screens that hold it up.

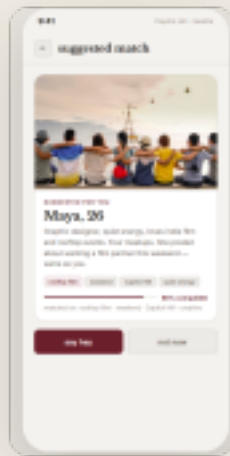
The first three screens are the whole product. The other three exist to make those three work.

THE CORE FLOW



01 POST THE PLAN

"Hiking partner for Rattlesnake Ledge this Sunday." An activity with a date — not a profile waiting to be found.



02 SEE THE REASON

Strong match — hiking pace · Sunday · North Bend. The app shows the tags it matched on, so saying yes is easy.



03 LAND THE MEETUP

Safety tip and a partner venue up top; four messages later it's "meet at the North Bend coffee shop at 6:45am → head to the trail together at 7."

EVERYTHING AROUND IT

Feed



• CHATS

A short list, every thread tied to a real plan. No dead conversations piling up.



• PROFILE

Verified badge, interests and completed meetups — proof you showed up, not a bio.

SECTION 07

Metrics

The one number that matters.

Weekly Successful Meetups (WSM)

Two matched users who met in real life **and** both submitted a post-meetup rating of 3.5★ or above within 48 hours.

Year 1 target

10,000 WSM / week

Year 2 target

50,000 WSM / week

HOW WE COUNT IT

Both sides confirm the meetup happened, both leave a rating within 48 hours, and both ratings clear 3.5★. One-sided confirmations and late ratings do not count.

WHY THOSE THRESHOLDS

3.5★ is the minimum acceptable rating for an individual meetup. The 3.8★ guardrail is the aggregate product-quality floor across all meetups. 48 hours keeps memory fresh and ratings honest.

WHAT IT CAN'T BE GAMED BY

Not signups — volume without value.
Not matches — a match nobody shows up for is worth nothing.
Not revenue — money follows good meetups, so this leads it.

WSM is the outcome that matters. If it stalls, growth spend can't fix the underlying product.

The full metrics framework.

Layer	Metric	Target	Why it matters
Acquisition	Signups	500 in one Seattle neighborhood by M3	Top-of-funnel volume
Acquisition	Referral rate	25% of signups	Word-of-mouth is working
Activation	Posts within 48 hrs	60%	They reached the core action
Engagement	Posts per active user	2+ / month	Habitual intent
Matching	Time to first match	< 2 hrs median	Time from post to an accepted match — the demand-side counterpart to post response time
Matching	Match acceptance rate	> 40%	Suggestions are relevant
Engagement	Post-to-meetup conversion	> 35%	Plans become reality
Retention	Post again within 14 days	45%	The loop repeats
Retention	30-day retention	40%	30-day retention — 40% target

Guardrails that protect the promise.

Safety incidents per 1,000 confirmed meetups

< 2

Above this, we pause growth and audit safety before scaling.

False profiles per 1,000 verified accounts

< 5

Breach triggers tighter verification and a manual review sweep.

Average meetup rating

> 3.8★

Aggregate product-quality floor across all meetups, distinct from the 3.5★ minimum for a single meetup. Falling below means matching quality is off; we revert to safer rules.

Post response time

< 4 hrs

Time from a post going live to its first inbound request — a supply-side signal. Slower means thin liquidity; we re-seed supply in that city.

SECTION 08

Monetization

Free for users. Funded by the ecosystem.

Venue Partnerships

Cafés, gyms and restaurants are featured as recommended first-meetup spots. Users get perks — a discount, a reserved table, priority booking.

Who pays

Local venues, monthly placement fee.

Why it works

Cohort sends real foot traffic at a known time — and the perk makes the first meetup easier to say yes to.

Experience Partnerships

Escape rooms, sports clubs and art studios are surfaced only when a matching activity is posted. Paid on performance, per booking.

Who pays

Experience operators, per completed booking.

Why it works

The recommendation lands at the exact moment of intent, so it reads as help rather than an ad.

Corporate Wellness

An annual license sold to HR teams as an employee benefit for distributed and remote workforces.

Who pays

Employers, annual seat-based license.

Why it works

Remote isolation is a budgeted HR problem, and this is contracted revenue that is less directly tied to consumer acquisition.

Aggregated Data Insights

Aggregated, city-level reports on what people actually want to do, where and when. Only aggregated, city-level insights are shared — never individual-level data.

Who pays

City planners, event organizers, developers.

Why it works

Posts are stated intent, not inferred behavior — a different kind of signal about urban demand.

Free for every user. Revenue comes from the ecosystem around the meetups, never from the people making them.

SECTION 09

Product Flywheel

What starts Cohort's growth loop?

A An employer signs a wellness deal

B Events get promoted on the platform

C Someone has a great meetup and tells a friend

the answer

D A venue partner brings in their customers

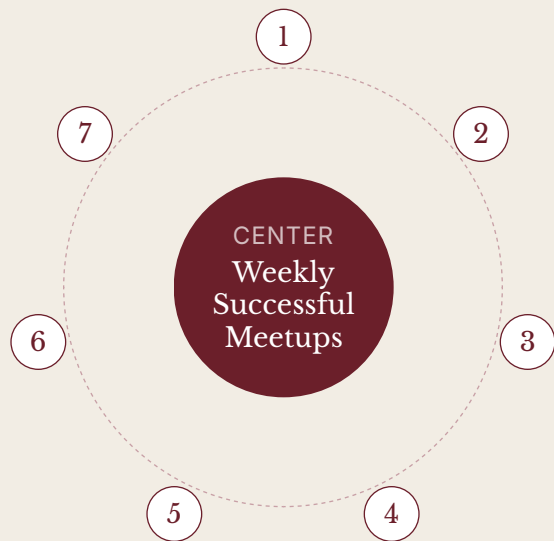
WHY C

Cohort is supposed to feel warm and cozy — like you always have someone. Word of mouth from a real, joyful human experience is the only start that matches that promise, and it requires no paid media by default: every good meetup is a micro-marketing event, so early organic CAC can remain low.

WHY NOT A, B OR D

Every one of them starts with a transaction — a contract, a promotion, a partner's customer list. They can accelerate a loop that already turns, but none of them can start it, and a product that leads with them feels sold to rather than cared for.

The loop that compounds.



- 1 **Great meetup** — two people have a genuinely good time.
- 2 **Word of mouth** — they tell a friend about it.
- 3 **New users join** — the friend signs up.
- 4 **More posts** — more activities get posted.
- 5 **Better AI matches** — more meetup data improves compatibility predictions.
- 6 **Venue partners grow** — more meetups draw more venues.
- 7 **Trust builds** — ratings & safety signals compound, back to step 1.

SECTION 10

GTM Strategy

Start with one neighborhood, not one country.

An app like this is only fun if people **near you** are already using it. Open in five cities and everyone sees an empty feed. Open in one neighborhood and the feed has enough activity to give people something to join this weekend.

WHERE WE START

One city: Seattle

Small enough to fill, big enough to matter.

One person: Sarah

New in town, wants a plan for this weekend — the easiest person to help first.

One goal: a busy feed

Not more users everywhere — enough users in one place that every post has a strong chance of getting an answer.

“One neighborhood with a live feed beats five cities with ghost towns.”

THE EMPTY-APP PROBLEM — AND THE FOUR FIXES

Nobody posts first on an empty app. So we make sure it is never empty on day one.

01 Founding users post first

Founding users post real plans before public launch, so the first arrival sees something to join.

02 Founding 100

100 hand-picked locals get early access and perks in exchange for actually posting.

03 Waitlist with social proof

People join knowing how many neighbors are already in — arriving to a crowd, not a void.

04 Three venues signed first

Every first meetup has a safe, welcoming place to go, with a perk attached.

Three phases to five cities.

Phase 1 · Seed

Months 1–3

Get 500 users concentrated in one Seattle neighborhood: community seeding, neighborhood drops, campus seeding, founding perks.

Targets

500 users · 100 meetups · <2 hr median match time

Phase 2 · Grow

Months 4–8

Activate word of mouth: meetup stories, micro-influencers, venue launch, PR.

Targets

10K users · 1,000 WSM/week · 25% referral signups

Phase 3 · Scale

Months 9–18

Replicate the playbook in 4 new cities: city captains, paid acquisition, B2B sales, data product.

Targets

5 cities · 200K users · \$2M ARR (Year 2 operating target)

SECTION 11

Key Challenges

Five risks, eyes open.

Cold start / density · Critical

Trust & safety · Critical

AI matching quality · Critical

Copycat risk · High

Behavior-change barrier · High

Deep dive — Challenge 1: Cold start

EVIDENCE

- Tinder seeded USC through campus networks and social events
- Density-threshold research (a16z)

What this tells us

Together, these examples point to the same risk: a marketplace with insufficient local density struggles to create value. The lesson is to manufacture local density before expanding geographically.

RESOLUTION

- Founding users post real plans pre-launch
- Founding 100 program
- Seattle-only launch, neighborhood focus

How this fixes it

We manufacture density instead of waiting for it — a feed that is already alive, 100 people committed to posting, and a footprint small enough that every post finds someone nearby.

Challenges 2 & 3 — keeping the first meetup good.

CHALLENGE 02 · CRITICAL

Staying safe as we get bigger

Meeting a stranger is the scary part. The more people join, the more chances someone behaves badly — and one bad story travels further than a hundred good ones.

What we know

48% of online dating users report at least one unwanted behavior (Pew Research, 2023), and romance scams accounted for \$1.14B in reported losses in 2023 (FTC, 2024).

What we do

Phone and social verification to even get in, AI flags unusual behavior patterns for review, both people rate each other afterwards, and the first meetup is nudged to a public venue. *In short: anonymity is harder, and every confirmed meetup can contribute a safety and quality signal.*

CHALLENGE 03 · CRITICAL

The AI suggesting bad matches

On day one the AI has almost no data to learn from. If early matches feel random, people decide the app doesn't work and never come back to test it again.

What we know

On day one, Cohort has limited behavioral data, so the first version should rely on predictable rules and onboarding signals before learning from behavior. Match Group's payers declined 5% in 2024, underscoring the pressure on mature matching products.

What we do

Launch on simple, predictable rules — same activity, same area, same time. Use onboarding answers as the AI's starting data, and automatically fall back to the rules if acceptance drops below 35%. *In short: boring and right beats clever and wrong.*

Challenges 4 & 5 — competition and habit.

CHALLENGE 04 · HIGH

A big app copying the idea

There is nothing stopping an established app from adding an “activity” tab. They have the users, the money and the engineers we don’t.

What we know

They have the users, money and engineering resources we don’t; Instagram launched Stories in 2016 and quickly surpassed Snapchat in daily Stories users.

What we do

Move faster than a big company’s roadmap, and build the one thing they can’t clone — a local community that already trusts each other. *In short: they can copy a feature; a local community that already trusts each other is far harder to copy.*

CHALLENGE 05 · HIGH

Getting people to post at all

Posting “anyone want to join me?” feels like admitting you have nobody to go with. Participation inequality means most users won’t contribute spontaneously.

What we know

The 90-9-1 rule: in most online communities 90% only watch. In our interviews, profile-first matching often produced conversations that never became plans.

What we do

Reframe it: you’re announcing a plan, not asking for company. The first post is guided with prompts and never a blank box, and private mode lets shy users take part quietly. *In short: make posting feel confident, not needy.*

APPENDIX

Sources

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